

Movers & Shakers



GOING WEST: Ravi Ruia

GOODBYE MUMBAI, NAMASTE LONDON

These days, Ravi Ruia is seen more in London than in Mumbai, setting tongues wagging about him shifting base. The buzz is that the 63-year old vice chairman of the Essar group spends a lot of time in the London office as it gives him flexibility in terms of seizing global opportunities and raising funds. The acquisition of Shell's refineries keeps Ruia and his team busy. But the team in London, which is in the process of being beefed up, has the mammoth task of overseeing the group's expansion into global markets. The group is investing in fast growing markets like Africa. Business tycoons like Anil Agarwal of Vedanta have already shifted base to London. Grapevine has it that he recently bought a new house in London. Will Ravi Ruia too make London his permanent home? It's anybody's guess.

In his father's footsteps

More than 10 years back, Dhirubhai Ambani was conferred a dean's medal by University of Pennsylvania's Wharton School. On Friday, Reliance Industries chairman Mukesh Ambani will receive a dean's medal from University of Pennsylvania's engineering & applied science's division for his "visionary leadership in the application of engineering technology." Eduardo Glandt, the University of Pennsylvania's dean, will confer the medal at a function in Mumbai's Oberoi Hotel.

The idiots come calling

The 3 Idiots created quite a stir on the IIM Bangalore campus last week. The crew of the recently-released movie 3 Idiots arranged a special screening for the students and faculty, and the audience was at the edge of their seats. Not because the movie was gripping, but so they could catch a glimpse of their friends and acquaintances from the IIM community who have done a few comes in the film.

HEAD HONCHOS KEEP WORKING A BIG SLICE

When You Operate In A Pressure-Cooker Environment, Burnout Can Come Easily. India Inc's Top Guns Tell ET How To Stay Grounded

Mahima Puri & Shreya Biswas
NEW DELHI

NO MATTER where he's travelling or how much of a backlog he has, Amar Babu, the 44-year old India MD of Lenovo, ensures he's back home in Mumbai on Fridays.

"I have only this amount of time for myself. It's a hectic life," he says.

And when he's with family, phone calls and emails are blocked out. The only luxury he allows himself is checking his inbox once a day, just in case there is something urgent. Weekends are spent taking his son to tennis class, catching a movie or making a trip to the mall with his wife. "I can't really claim that I have a great work-life balance, but this is the least I can do," he says.

Similarly, Divakar Kaza, president — HR of Lupin, too, prefers to fly down to his family in Bangalore every weekend.

Babu and Kaza represent a growing tribe of executives who take time out for their family and themselves, despite tough work schedules and high-stress jobs. In their own quiet ways, they're cutting off from the professional network and bringing more balance into their lives.

In the process, executives are devoting more time to hobbies and interests. ABG's financial services CEO Ajay Srinivasan, for one, doesn't miss his weekend golf sessions. And with his two children, aged 16 and 13 and wife, he makes it a point to catch up on the latest movies. Mr Srinivasan also loves reading non-fiction and listening to Indian classical music. And while doing all this, his cell phone is switched off. "I believe in balance and this is what we try practising even at the workplace," says the 45-year-old executive.

Mr Srinivasan leads by example. He says even at his workplace, the lights and air conditioners are turned off at 7 pm. In case anyone plans to work beyond this, he has to seek special permission. "If anybody is working in the office till late on a regular basis, he is either inefficient or his profile design is faulty. We believe this should be taken care of by the organisation," Mr Srinivasan adds.

Then there are others who make sure they switch off from work at the end of a long, hard day. While PepsiCo India's executive director — human resources Pavan Bhatia is accessible on the phone, he avoids taking calls between 8 pm and 8.45 pm, a time he reserves exclusively for his three-year-old daughter. "My daughter sleeps at 8.45 pm, and this gives me just 45 minutes to spend with her. One needs to appreciate the time being spent with another person, whether it's at home or at work," he says. While some of these executives believe it's important to develop the ability to detach from others believe there's nothing like "I have a life."

PA
PEPSICO INDIA EXECUTIVE

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"The more you stretch yourself, the more you will have at your disposal," says Ramo CEO of IndusInd Bank. Mr Sobti wakes up every day to play golf. He also goes walking with his wife and attends art exhibitions.

But he agrees it's not always easy to switch off from everything. Instead, one has to find ways to separate personal time from professional obligations. Kaza of Lupin agrees, maintaining a healthy work-life balance is not only being productive, but is also a vital aspect to how creative and innovative one is as an individual. It becomes more important as you evolve professionally," he says, as he is seriously pursuing his interest in photography.

Whether an executive can afford to cut himself off from day-to-day work depends on the profession he is in. For example, executives in sectors such as consulting, IT require people to be deeply involved in work. But over the years, there has been an

MAINTAIN BALANCE

KEEP WORK ASIDE FOR THE QUALITY OF LIFE



AJAY SRINIVASAN
CEO, ABG FINANCIAL SERVICES

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WORK-LIFE BALANCE
WEEKEND GOLF SESSIONS. CATCHES UP ON THE LATEST MOVIES, READS NON-FICTION & LISTENS TO INDIAN CLASSICAL MUSIC

PAVAN BHATIA
PEPSICO INDIA EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR, HR

NEEDS TO APPRECIATE THE TIME SPENT WITH ANOTHER PERSON

WORK-LIFE BALANCE
TAKES CALLS BETWEEN 8 PM & 8.45 PM. SPENDS TIME WITH HIS THREE-YEAR-OLD DAUGHTER



RAMESH SOBTI, CEO, INDUSIND BANK

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WORK-LIFE BALANCE
PLAYS GOLF EVERY MORNING. GOES FOR LONG WALKS, ATTENDS ART EXHIBITIONS

to develop the ability to detach from work. Believe there's nothing like "I have no time." "The more you stretch yourself, the more time you have at your disposal," says Ramesh Sobti, IndusInd Bank. Mr Sobti wakes up at 5.30 every day to play golf. He also goes for long walks with his wife and attends art exhibitions. He agrees it's not always easy to cut yourself out from everything. Instead, one has to learn to separate personal time from professional obligations. Kaza of Lupin agrees, "Maintaining a healthy work-life balance is the key to being productive, but is also an important aspect to how creative and innovative you are as an individual. It becomes more important as you evolve professionally," he says, adding he is personally pursuing his interest in photography. "Other than an executive can afford to completely detach himself off from day-to-day work also depends on the profession he is in. For example, executives in sectors such as consulting, IT and sales have to be deeply involved with work. Over the years, there has been an attitudinal

change and people are aware of each other's preferences. "Five to seven years ago, a professional call could have stretched till 11 in the evening, even on weekends. That doesn't happen anymore," says K Sudarshan, managing partner at EMA Partners International, a Mumbai-based executive search firm. "Nowadays, peers respect an individual's personal space. They don't call up on weekends unless it's extremely urgent," says Babu of Lenovo. The high level of connectivity — through emails, Blackberrys — makes it difficult for executives to be away from work. In a high-growth market, the stakes are high, and companies paying fat salary packages want maximum returns. But psychologists point out that if a balance is not maintained, it may take a toll on employee performance, often leading to marital discord and disharmony in personal lives, say psychologists. "Executives work even when they are not in office. Hence, switching off from the outside world helps them connect with themselves," says Ashum Gupta, who teaches psychology at the University of Delhi.



Sudeshna Sen

What's worrying you at the workplace and around it? You ask, we answer

I work in advertising. My boss is a rather well known figure in the industry. For three times in a row, my ideas have been implemented in key campaigns and he never gives me any credit. He gives us pep talks about 'teamwork' every once in a while and is feted by the outside world for our wonderful campaigns. Should I just call his bluff? Will that limit my career?

FRUSTRATED COPYWRITER, MUMBAI

Dear Frustrated Copywriter,

The one thing you don't do when you are in advertising working for a high-profile boss is call his bluff openly. That will not only limit your career, it might end it. The proverbial scorned woman is a kitten compared to successful creative egos. Your boss, who was probably himself a frustrated copywriter like you in some historical time, probably thinks he's doing more than his share for you by letting you work on his key campaigns and using your ideas. Where he comes from, you need to earn the right to individual credit. Like when you get to his level. That's what his bosses did to him, that's the way of the ad world. After all, your clients aren't paying for your work, they're paying for his brand name. You can take him out for a drink and gently let him know you'd like a public word of praise, and it would motivate you to work harder.

Or, very simply, you can take your successful campaigns and your creative portfolio and head straight to the agency next door. If you are as good as you say, you should get a red carpet welcome. Every ad agency knows campaigns are produced by vast numbers of unacknowledged minions like you. But then, the same thing could happen there too. At the least, it will make your current boss value you more if you can wangle a super job offer from a rival.

I work for a leading IT firm in Bangalore as a team leader and my problem is I have lost all motivation after I was benched for six months last year. Now our team is back in the thick of projects but I have developed a sense of emptiness. It's not like severe depression, and I'm quite happy when I'm with family, but somehow I'm unable to work. It's not like I was unhappy at being benched either. I enjoyed the break in fact. Or so I thought. Please fix me.

PRABHU, BANGALORE

Dear Prabhu,

You need to see your doctor, preferably a psychiatrist, like tomorrow. I'm not qualified to fix you on this one.

Stress and clinical depression is one of the most misunderstood and under-diagnosed problems in corporate India. As far as I know, the symptoms can take many forms, ranging from the mild — the general feeling of emptiness you describe — to the severe, like an inability to get out of bed or manic hyperactivity. You may not have a medical problem, but even if you do, it isn't the end of the world. You don't have to tell anyone, and you don't have to feel depressed about being depressed either. It can easily be cured with medication or a change in lifestyle, in as short a time as a week. Meanwhile, you have to change your lifestyle. If you are in IT, your food habits and work hours are probably erratic. It's essential you start an exercise regime, see a nutritionist to help you design a balanced, regular diet within the framework of your hours, and plan your leisure actively. Do things like days out or holidays. Go bowling or go-karting, attend music concerts and plays, start a hobby or do social work, whatever you like, together with family and friends. Proper leisure is an essential part of staying healthy and happy. Whatever you do, don't ignore it. Seek medical advice immediately.

Have queries? Need advice? Write to qbicle@indiatimes.com